Making compost
feed it, leave it, use it

Good compost making simply involves not throwing away anything of organic origin. Kitchen scraps, hedge trimmings, pet litter, cardboard boxes - a good compost bin will take all you throw at it and ask for more. Good compost will reward you with an abundance of lush, tasty and, above all, cheap food.



A mixture going in; dark, crumbly compost coming out. Return coarse pieces to the active bin.

Mixed ingredients

A good rule of thumb is “half greens, half browns”. Combine soft green material, such as vegetable peelings and fresh leaves, with browns such as torn plain cardboard and chopped stalks. Mix grass clippings through other material rather than adding a thick wet lump. Compost autumn leaves in a heap on their own; they are slow to rot.

Damp, not soaked

Dampen dry cardboard and other dry additions as they go in. Close the lid to keep heavy rain out and moisture in, then check below the fresh top layer during dry weather. A large bin kept moist may not need turning. If yours stalls, check for dry corners or wet clumps; break these up, adding water to dry material or dry browns to a soggy mix. Then turn with a fork.

Judge the compost, not the calendar

Finished compost is dark, crumbly and earthy, with little recognisable soft plant material. Pick out remaining coarse stalks and return them to the filling bin. Give slow material more time. A resting bin may spend many months getting ready; the plants will not thank you for impatience.

Put it back to work

Spread mature compost on no-dig beds, or incorporate it when preparing a dug bed. Keep it clear of established soft stems. For a combined sowing and potting-on mix, sieve equal volumes of good mature compost and garden topsoil and mix them thoroughly. Make in batches as needed; the mix does not store well. Try a small batch first: the ingredients vary from garden to garden.

Keep plastic-coated card and doubtful “compostable” packaging out. Unless you have a suitable system that excludes rodents, send cooked food, meat, fish and dairy to your council’s food-waste collection where available.

John: Compost and Potting Mixtures; Compost Method; Five Things; Winter Composting; Why We Make Compost.